

CHAPTER 2

IN THE DOCK

'What's the charge?'

In the morning, I went to a dirty loo attached to the Vanchiyoor Police Station, and was on my way back to the bench when I heard the commotion. Newspaper reporters and photographers were thronging the police station to get a glimpse of Nambi Narayanan, the traitor who sold state secrets to Pakistan through two Maldivian women who acted as honey traps. Then I saw the four-column news below the fold of the day's *Malayala Manorama*: ISRO spy case mastermind arrested. An enterprising journalist had managed to get an old photograph of mine from somewhere to go with the text. Since I could not read much Malayalam, and since it did not matter what they wrote about me, I left the newspaper there and sat on the bench as photographers clicked away.

Among the journalists was a man in a kurta with a sling bag—the trademark of many journalists of Kerala then. He spoke only Hindi, and appeared to be at a loss as the other journalists and policemen chatted away in Malayalam. It would only be days later that I would see this man again, this time as a CBI officer. P M Nair, the officer, was in disguise to glean what the buzz about the spy case was all about.

Nair, a Deputy Inspector General with the CBI, was in Trivandrum on another assignment. He was to return two days later when his boss asked him to stay back: The Kerala Government had sent a requisition for a CBI probe into what was turning out to be the ISRO spy case. The CBI top brass